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Clinician handbook

Cedar Grove Counseling

EDITION 2026

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CHAPTER 1

A welcome from the director

We are glad you are here. Cedar Grove is a small group practice, and every clinician shapes how it feels to walk through our door. This handbook covers how we work day to day. Your supervisor will walk you through anything that is unclear.

- Read one chapter a day in your first two weeks.
- Bring questions to supervision.
- Nothing here replaces your licensing board’s rules.

> Dr. Rachel Moore, Clinical director

CHAPTER 2

Our mission

We help people through hard seasons with care that is skilled, warm and on time. We measure ourselves by whether clients feel heard and whether they get better.

- Clients first, always.
- Do the paperwork so the care can happen.
- Ask for help early.

CHAPTER 3

Who we serve

Our clients are adults, couples and teens across the county. Many are seeing a counselor for the first time. About a third of sessions are by telehealth.

- Adults 18 and over
- Couples
- Teens 13 to 17 with a guardian’s consent

CHAPTER 4

Your first week

Week one is for set-up and people, not a full caseload. You will meet your supervisor, sign your agreements and get every account working.

- Sign the confidentiality agreement
- Set up SimplePractice, Zoom and Slack
- Shadow two intakes

CHAPTER 5

Your supervisor

Your supervisor is your first call for anything clinical. You will meet weekly, and you can always ask for an extra check-in when a case worries you.

- Weekly one-hour supervision
- Same-day consult for safety concerns
- Notes on every supervision session

CHAPTER 6

Office hours and access

The office is open 8 am to 8 pm on weekdays and 9 am to 2 pm on Saturdays. Evening sessions end by 8 pm so the building can be locked on time.

- Front desk staffed 9 am to 5 pm
- Last session starts at 7 pm
- Saturday sessions by arrangement

CHAPTER 7

Keys, alarms and parking

You will get a key fob on day one. The alarm code is personal: never share it. Staff park in the rear lot so the front stays free for clients.

- Report a lost fob the same day
- Arm the alarm if you leave last
- Rear lot for staff

CHAPTER 8

Scheduling in SimplePractice

Every appointment lives in SimplePractice. Clients book through the portal or the front desk; you manage your own availability.

- Keep your availability current
- Block time for notes
- Never book outside the system

CHAPTER 9

Session length and timing

Standard sessions are 53 minutes. Start on time and end on time, so the next client is not kept waiting.

- Intake: 60 minutes
- Standard: 53 minutes
- Couples: 60 minutes

CHAPTER 10

Cancellations and no-shows

Clients cancel with 24 hours’ notice. A late cancellation or no-show is charged the fee in our policy, unless there is an emergency.

- Mark it in SimplePractice the same day
- Reach out after two no-shows
- Talk to your supervisor before discharge

CHAPTER 11

The intake process

Every new client completes the intake packet before the first session. You review it before you meet them and note any safety flags.

- Intake packet complete
- Consent signed
- Safety screen reviewed

CHAPTER 12

Informed consent

Consent is a conversation, not a form. Explain how counseling works, the limits of confidentiality and how to reach us.

- Review consent in session one
- Revisit it when anything changes
- Document that you did

CHAPTER 13

Confidentiality basics

What a client shares stays in the room and in the record. Talk about cases only with your supervisor or in case review, never in shared spaces.

- No names in Slack or email
- Lock your screen
- Close the door

CHAPTER 14

Limits of confidentiality

There are times we must share information: risk of serious harm, suspected abuse of a child or vulnerable adult, and a court order. Clients hear this at intake.

- Harm to self or others
- Suspected abuse or neglect
- Court orders

CHAPTER 15

Mandated reporting

If you suspect abuse or neglect, you report it. Tell your supervisor the same day and document the report.

- Report within the required time
- Tell your supervisor
- Document what you reported and when

CHAPTER 16

Documentation timelines

Notes are finished within 24 hours of the session. Treatment plans are written by the third session and reviewed every 90 days.

- Progress note: 24 hours
- Treatment plan: by session three
- Plan review: every 90 days

CHAPTER 17

Progress notes

We use the SOAP format. Keep notes short, factual and clinical. Write as if the client will read them, because they may.

- Subjective
- Objective
- Assessment and plan

CHAPTER 18

Treatment plans

A plan names the problem, the goals and how you will measure progress. Write it with the client, in their words where you can.

- Two to three goals
- Measurable objectives
- Review dates

CHAPTER 19

Discharge summaries

When care ends, write a short summary: why the client came, what changed and any referrals. Finish it within a week.

- Reason for discharge
- Progress on goals
- Referrals given

CHAPTER 20

Telehealth sessions

Telehealth runs on the practice Zoom account only. Confirm the client's location at the start of every session in case of an emergency.

- Private room, headphones on
- Confirm location
- Have a backup phone number

CHAPTER 21

Crisis response

If a client is at risk, stay with them, follow the crisis protocol and call your supervisor. Never leave a client at risk alone.

- Follow the crisis and safety protocol
- Call your supervisor
- Document everything

CHAPTER 22

Safety planning

Every client with a risk flag gets a written safety plan, made together, and a copy to keep.

- Warning signs
- Coping steps
- People and numbers to call

CHAPTER 23

Consultation and case review

Case review meets every other Thursday. Bring one case you are unsure about; the group is there to help, not judge.

- Every other Thursday, 12 pm
- De-identify all cases
- Notes kept by the facilitator

CHAPTER 24

Supervision hours

Associates and interns log supervision hours in the supervision log every week. Your supervisor signs it monthly.

- Log weekly
- Signed monthly
- Keep a copy for your board

CHAPTER 25

Licensure tracking

Keep your license, insurance and CE certificates current. The office reminds you 60 days before anything expires.

- License number on file
- Malpractice insurance
- CE certificates

CHAPTER 26

Continuing education

Each clinician gets a yearly CE budget. Ask your supervisor before booking, and share what you learn at case review.

- Yearly CE budget
- Pre-approval
- Share back with the team

CHAPTER 27

Caseload expectations

Caseloads build over your first three months. Associates aim for 20 to 25 sessions a week once settled.

- Month 1: up to 10 a week
- Month 2: up to 18
- Month 3: full caseload

CHAPTER 28

Billing and superbills

The office handles billing. You make sure every session is coded and signed the same day so claims go out on time.

- Code every session
- Sign notes promptly
- Flag any billing questions

CHAPTER 29

Insurance and authorizations

Some plans need an authorization before session one or after a set number of sessions. The front desk tracks this; tell them when a plan changes.

- Check authorization status
- Update insurance changes
- Never promise coverage

CHAPTER 30

Fees and sliding scale

Our fees are on the website. A limited number of sliding-scale spots are available; the director approves them.

- Published fees
- Sliding scale by approval
- Review yearly

CHAPTER 31

Client communication

Use the SimplePractice portal for messages. Keep messages short and about logistics; clinical work happens in session.

- Portal messages only
- Reply within one business day
- No clinical advice by message

CHAPTER 32

Email and texting

Never send client details by personal email or text. Appointment reminders go out automatically from SimplePractice.

- No personal phones for clients
- No client names in email
- Automatic reminders only

CHAPTER 33

Social media

We do not connect with current or former clients on social media, and we never post about a client, even without a name.

- No friending clients
- No posts about sessions
- See the social media policy

CHAPTER 34

Dual relationships

Avoid relationships with clients outside counseling. In a small town it happens; talk to your supervisor when it does.

- No business with clients
- Tell your supervisor
- Document the plan

CHAPTER 35

Gifts from clients

Small, one-time gifts may be accepted with care. Anything over a small value is politely declined.

- Small and occasional only
- Talk it through
- Note it in the chart

CHAPTER 36

Self-care and burnout

This work is heavy. Use your time off, keep your lunch break and tell your supervisor when you are running low.

- Protected lunch break
- Use your time off
- Ask for help early

CHAPTER 37

Time off requests

Request time off at least four weeks ahead in the shared calendar. Arrange coverage for any clients at risk.

- Four weeks’ notice
- Coverage plan
- Out-of-office message on

CHAPTER 38

Sick days

If you are sick, stay home. Tell the front desk by 7 am so clients can be moved or seen by telehealth.

- Tell the front desk by 7 am
- Offer telehealth if well enough
- Rest

CHAPTER 39

Professional conduct

Be on time, be kind, and keep your notes current. Treat colleagues with the same respect you give clients.

- On time
- Respectful
- Current notes

CHAPTER 40

Leaving the practice

Give 60 days’ notice so every client has a good transition. Finish all notes and hand over open cases in writing.

- 60 days’ notice
- Written handover
- All notes finished